

Internal Family Systems: The Many Faces of Your Wisdom

Introduction: You Are Beautifully Complex

IFS recognizes that you naturally have different aspects or "parts" of yourself - and this is completely normal and healthy. These parts developed to help you navigate life and often carry important wisdom. All of us have different aspects of our personality that show up in different situations.

Think of it like this: You probably act differently at work than you do with close friends, differently when you're stressed than when you're relaxed. These aren't fake versions of you - they're all authentic parts of who you are.

Your Self: The Calm Center

- Your core essence - naturally curious, compassionate, courageous, and calm
- Always present, even when parts are activated
- Your internal healer - knows how to lead with wisdom and love
- Ketamine often helps you access Self when protective parts step back

Protective Parts: Your Inner Guardians

Managers (everyday protectors):

- The Achiever: "If I'm successful, I'll be safe"
- The People Pleaser: "If everyone likes me, I won't be abandoned"
- The Controller: "If I manage everything, nothing bad will happen"
- The Critic: "If I find flaws first, I won't be disappointed"

Firefighters (crisis responders):

- The Rager: Explosive anger when boundaries are crossed
- The Escape Artist: Substances, sex, shopping to avoid pain
- The Rebel: "I'll do whatever I want, no one can control me"

Exiled Parts: Your Tender Wisdom Keepers

- The Hurt Child: Carries pain that needs witnessing
- The Joyful One: Your natural creativity and wonder
- The Angry One: Legitimate rage at injustice
- The Scared One: Important survival information

Part I: Your Protective Parts - Your Inner Security Team

Instructions: Read through these descriptions and check any that feel familiar. Don't overthink it - just notice what resonates.

Manager Parts (Your Daily Protectors)

□ The Achiever/Perfectionist

- Always pushing to do better, be more, accomplish more
- Believes: "If I'm successful enough, I'll be safe/loved/worthy"
- Shows up as: Working late, never feeling "good enough," setting high standards

□ The People Pleaser

- Always putting others' needs first, avoiding conflict
- Believes: "If everyone likes me, I won't be abandoned or rejected"
- Shows up as: Saying yes when you mean no, difficulty with boundaries

□ The Controller/Planner

- Needs to know what's happening, manages details obsessively
- Believes: "If I control everything, nothing bad will happen"
- Shows up as: Over-organizing, anxiety about uncertainty, micromanaging

□ The Caretaker/Rescuer

- Always helping others, taking responsibility for their feelings
- Believes: "If I take care of everyone, I'll be needed and loved"
- Shows up as: Fixing other people's problems, exhaustion from giving too much

□ The Strong One/Stoic

- Never shows vulnerability, always has it together
- Believes: "If I'm strong, I won't get hurt and others can depend on me"
- Shows up as: Difficulty asking for help, pushing through pain

□ The Critic/Judge

- Constantly evaluating, finding flaws in self or others
- Believes: "If I spot problems first, I can avoid disappointment"
- Shows up as: Inner criticism, judging others, never feeling satisfied

□ The Vigilant One

- Always scanning for danger or threats
- Believes: "I must stay alert to keep us safe"
- Shows up as: Hypervigilance, difficulty relaxing, anxiety

Firefighter Parts (Your Crisis Responders)

□ The Rager

- Explosive anger when boundaries are crossed
- Believes: "If I get big and scary, they'll back off"
- Shows up as: Outbursts, road rage, fighting

□ The Escape Artist

- Uses substances, behaviors, or distractions to avoid pain
- Believes: "I need to get away from this feeling right now"
- Shows up as: Drinking, drugs, shopping, sex, scrolling, workaholism

□ The Rebel

- Does the opposite of what's expected or demanded
- Believes: "No one can control me"
- Shows up as: Breaking rules, self-sabotage when things go well

□ The Chaos Creator

- Stirs up drama when things feel too calm or vulnerable
- Believes: "Familiar chaos is safer than unknown peace"
- Shows up as: Starting fights, making impulsive decisions

Your Protective Parts Reflection

Which protective parts did you recognize in yourself?	
Which part feels most active in your daily life right now?	
What do you think this part is protecting you from?	
How long has this part been working so hard for you?	

Part II: Your Exiled Parts - Your Inner Treasures

□ The Hurt Child

- Carries pain from past experiences
- Needs: Comfort, safety, someone to witness their pain
- May show up as: Feeling small, wanting to hide, emotional reactions that feel too big

□ The Scared One

- Holds your fears and worries
- Needs: Protection, reassurance, safety
- May show up as: Anxiety, panic, feeling like something bad will happen

□ The Angry One

- Carries legitimate rage about injustices or harm
- Needs: To be heard, validation, justice
- May show up as: Sudden anger, feeling like you want to scream or fight

□ The Sad One

- Holds grief, loss, disappointment
- Needs: Comfort, permission to cry, someone to care
- May show up as: Deep sadness, crying, feeling heavy

□ The Lonely One

- Yearns for connection and belonging
- Needs: Companionship, understanding, love
- May show up as: Feeling isolated, desperate for connection, fear of abandonment

□ The Joyful One

- Your natural wonder, playfulness, and delight
- Needs: Permission to play, safety to be spontaneous
- May show up as: Sudden happiness, wanting to dance or create, childlike excitement

□ The Creative One

- Your artistic expression, imagination, innovation
- Needs: Time, space, materials, encouragement
- May show up as: Urges to create, daydreaming, seeing beauty everywhere

□ The Wild One

- Your instincts, sexuality, primal energy
- Needs: Freedom, expression, acceptance
- May show up as: Wanting to break free, sexual energy, connection to nature

□ **The Wise One**

- Your intuition, deep knowing, spiritual connection
- Needs: Quiet, respect, trust in its guidance
- May show up as: Gut feelings, dreams, sudden knowing

Your Exiled Parts Reflection:

Which exiled parts did you recognize?	
Which ones feel most hidden or buried in your daily life?	
Which ones do you feel most protective of or worried about?	
Which ones bring you the most joy when they're allowed to emerge?	

Part III: Self - Your Natural Leader

Self is not a part - it's your core essence that naturally knows how to lead with:

- Curiosity instead of judgment
- Compassion instead of criticism
- Calm instead of reactivity
- Connection instead of isolation
- Courage instead of fear
- Creativity instead of rigidity
- Clarity instead of confusion

Recognizing When Self is Leading:

- You feel genuinely curious about your parts instead of frustrated with them
- You can stay present with difficult emotions without being overwhelmed
- You naturally want to care for the hurt parts of yourself
- You feel connected to your own wisdom and intuition
- You can set boundaries with love instead of anger
- You feel grounded and present in your body
- You naturally extend compassion to others

Self Reflection

When do you most feel like your authentic Self?	
What helps you access this calm, centered state?	
How does it feel different when Self is leading versus when parts are in charge?	

Preparing for Ketamine with Parts Awareness

Before Your Session

Which parts feel excited about ketamine therapy?	
Which parts feel nervous or scared?	
What do your protective parts need to hear to feel safer?	
Which exiled parts are you hoping might be witnessed or healed?	
What would it feel like if Self could lead during your session?	

Remember: All Your Parts Are Welcome

Every part of you developed for good reasons and carries important information. There are no "bad" parts - only parts that may be stuck in old roles that no longer serve you.

Your job is not to get rid of parts, but to:

- Get curious about them
- Appreciate how they've helped you
- Help them find new, healthier roles
- Let Self lead with compassion

During ketamine sessions, parts may:

- Step back and let Self lead
- Show up to be witnessed and healed
- Share their stories and needs
- Find new relationships with each other

Trust your system's timing and wisdom. Your parts will reveal themselves when it feels safe.

